RISE OF THE IMPERIAL JAPANESE NAVY



An archetypal hero in a modern setting
Japanese artists were quick to commemorate the navy's exploits in the Sino-Japanese War. Here, Lieutenant Commander Sakamoto of the *Akagi*, a gunboat that fought at Yalu River, gestures defiantly at the Chinese.

JAPAN'S IMPERIAL NAVY had an extraordinarily brief lifespan. Created in the late 1860s and first blooded in battle against China in 1894, it grew to be the world's third greatest naval force before abruptly ceasing to exist after the total defeat of Japan in 1945. The Imperial Navy was conceived as part of a wider project to modernize Japan and challenge the supremacy of the European powers and the United States. Its great victory over the Russian navy at Tsushima in 1905 was a stunning rebuff to prevailing assumptions of white racial superiority. The Imperial Navy embodied both Japan's impressive ability to adopt Western technology and its own warrior tradition, which gave Japanese forces their particular spirit of disciplined, sometimes fatalistic self-sacrifice.

BORN OF HUMILIATION

When Commodore Matthew Perry anchored four American steam warships off Edo—modern-day Tokyo—in July 1853, Japan had no national navy with which to repel this foreign intrusion. Its defenselessness was soon exploited, as the United States was joined by Britain, France, and the Netherlands in bullying a country for whose traditions they had no respect. In 1863 the British Royal Navy bombarded the Japanese city of Kagoshima, and the following year an international force shelled rebels opposed to foreign influence at Shimonoseki. These humiliations set in train a process of upheaval in Japan that resulted in the restoration of a strong central government under Emperor Meiji and the crushing of the samurai clans who opposed this. Japan then embarked on a breakneck rush to modernization in order to take on the West on its own terms.

During the civil strife surrounding the Meiji Restoration, an ad-hoc Imperial Navy was created from assorted ships of samurai clans

Triumph of the new navy
The first serious test for the Imperial Japanese Navy came when it took on a Chinese fleet at the battle of Yalu River in 1894. The Japanese cruisers sank five enemy ships, without suffering the loss of a single vessel.